

Ten Years in Tempe

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A New Era in Tempe

After eleven years with the Arizona State Sun Devils, Coach Bobby Hurley will not return for another season. He exited in a very unceremonious fashion after a frustrating season capped off by the most lopsided defeat in Big 12 Tournament history at the hands of Iowa State [2].

Hurley's Record at ASU		All Games		Conference		March	
Seasons	Conference	W	L	W	L	W	L
2015-24	Pac-12	155	131	79	88	2	3
2024-26	Big-12	30	36	11	27	0	0

Figure 1: Bobby Hurley's Win-Loss Record as ASU Coach

Eleven years is a long time for a single coach's regime, especially for a non-blue blood. ASU's transition to the Big 12 has been ugly and underwhelming, but my goal here is to assess Coach Hurley's entire stay at ASU, not just the difficult ending. I'm going to cover how Hurley came up short in three different areas: recruiting/personnel, on-court performance, and, most importantly, how the Devils fared against the Arizona Wildcats!

The Recruiter

Say what you will about Arizona State's on-court performance under Hurley, but the man can certainly recruit (Figure 2). Arizona State is not exactly a marquee destination, and yet Hurley still managed to compile a top-50 class in eight out of his eleven seasons and a top-30 class in six.

Hurley also had strong transfer classes, but he lost some momentum in his last four seasons. It's well established that college basketball has become the "wild west" in the age of the transfer portal. Hurley initially stayed afloat in the new era. However, his last four seasons contained three of his lowest-ranked recruiting classes. Prior to the difficult ending, he always made sure the Sun Devils had a strong freshman class or a strong group of transfers. In fact, some of the best players during Hurley's tenure were transfers (Figure 3).

However, his 2024 freshman class was his highest-ranked class while at ASU. This season may very well have been the tipping point for Hurley's time at ASU. The Sun Devils had merged from the Pac-12 to the Big 12 and made a huge recruiting splash. They

	Recruiting Class Rank	
Season	Overall	Transfer
2015-16	97	N/A
2016-17	17	N/A
2017-18	26	1
2018-19	14	N/A
2019-20	38	N/A
2020-21	8	3
2021-22	28	5
2022-23	48	14
2023-24	58	43
2024-25	7	61
2025-26	93	71

Figure 2: Hurley's ASU's recruiting class rankings

Name	Summary	March?
Torian Graham	18.6 pts, 38.7 3P%, 4.2 reb	
Shannon Evans	15.7 pts, 3.9 ast, 3.3 reb, 1.3 stl, 36.5 3P% in two seasons	*
Zylan Cheatham	12.1 pts, 10.3, 3.2 ast, 1.6 stl + blk, All Pac-12 in '19	*
Alonzo Verge Jr.	14.2 pts, 3.7 reb, 2.9 ast, 1.3 stl, Pac-12 6MOY in '20	
DJ Horne	12.5 pts, 3.2 reb, 2.2 ast, 35.7 3P% in two seasons	*
Dez Cambridge	13.6 pts, 3.5 reb, 1.7 stl in 22-23	*
Frankie Collins	13.8 pts, 4.4 reb, 3.2 ast, 2.6 stl in 23-24, All-Defense	*
Warren Washington	9.2 pts, 6.9 reb, 1.8 blk (career-high reb and blk)	*
Alston Mason	13.8 pts, 4.0 ast, 57.8 TS%	
Moe Odum	16.4 pts, 5.7 ast (3.2 tov), 3.1 reb, 1.4 stl, 56.3 TS%	
Pig Johnson	13.2 pts, 3.2 reb, 56.4 TS%	

Figure 3: Hurley's greatest transfer hits while at ASU

brought in three Top-100 recruits including Jayden Quaintance, the highest ranked freshman prospect in the history of the program. In addition to the freshmen, ASU brought in three great transfers: Alston Mason (All-MVC at Missouri State), Basheer Jihad (All-MAC at Ball State), and B.J. Freeman (All-Horizon at Milwaukee). They also brought in Adam Miller from LSU, a former top recruit with a lethal lefty stroke. This team was loaded; they were undersized, but they had experience and young talent falling out of their pockets.

The Big 12 is the scariest conference in America for a reason:

2024-25 Arizona State: **13-20, 4-16** in the Big 12 (both worst under Hurley)

The Sun Devils were not ready for the Big 12 gauntlet. Their conference schedule included matchups with SEVEN different ranked opponents. It was a little different than the Pac-12. The move to the Big 12 demanded a higher standard, and the Devils couldn't reach it. They had more conference games in which they lost by double digits than wins.

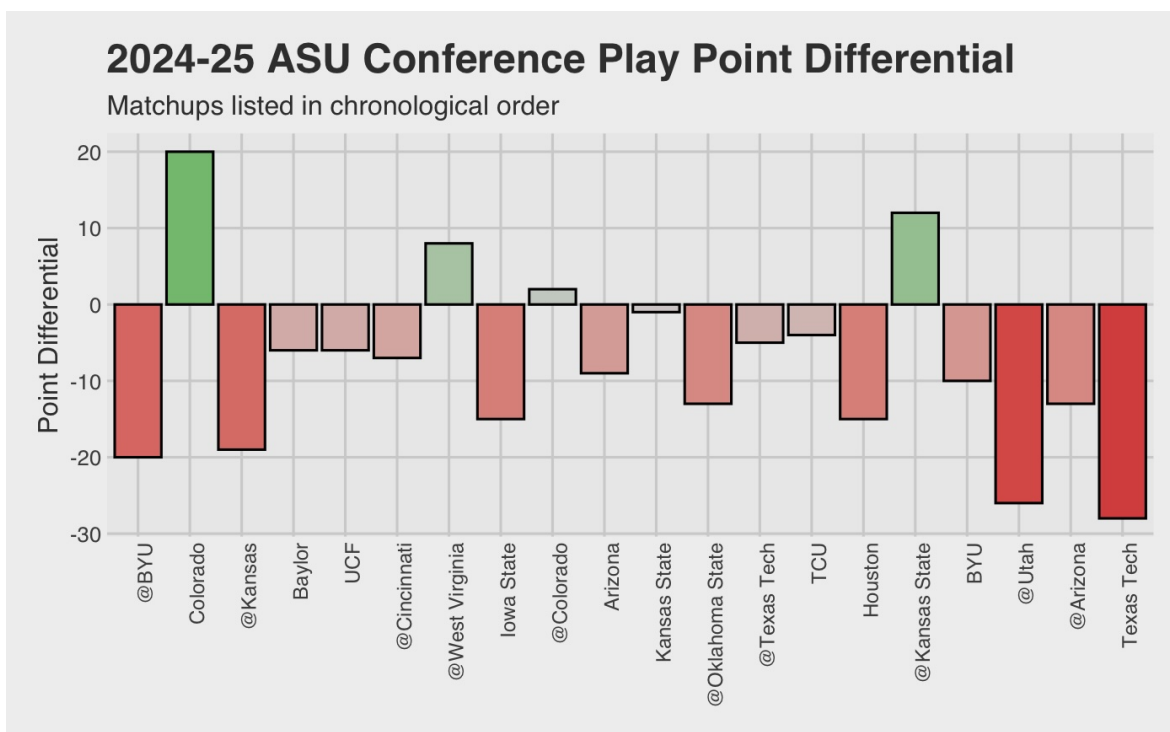


Figure 4: Ouch

Coach Hurley's last season was emblematic of another issue he experienced while in Tempe: Players skipping town. 2.2% of the minutes played for the 2025-26 Devils were played by returning players from 2024-25. Modern college basketball is synonymous with high turnover, but that is absurdly low. This trend got progressively worse for Coach Hurley (Figure 5).

Obviously, the NIL era makes it difficult for coaches to keep players together. The freedom is great for the players, but the coaches are in hell having to recruit and *re-recruit* their players. However, this trend of short stays simply won't suffice in a Power 5 conference and especially the Big 12. That conference is full of *programs* and teams with established identities and cores: Houston, Iowa State, Arizona, Texas Tech, Baylor. Even the other former Pac-12 schools Colorado and Utah had much higher retention rates. These figures are comparable to mid-major schools that are constantly fighting against bigger schools from poaching their players.

Looking at Figures 2 and 5, there are a few conclusions one could draw. The NIL era has been very unkind to Coach Hurley or his coaching style wears very thin when given enough time. We have to remember that ASU is the first time that a program truly handed the keys to him; he was given the Sun Devils' job after his two-year stint at the University of Buffalo where his group earned a tournament berth. Knowing both how Hurley brought a John Stockton-esque attitude to the game as player and how his brother operates at a similar level of intensity, it could be fair to assert that Bobby's coaching style is less tolerable if success doesn't follow.

Anecdotal evidence aside, there have been several recruits that did not pan out as well as players that left Coach Hurley's Devils and had success elsewhere:

- Jethro Tshisumpa (4-star in 2016)
 - 26 games, 7.4 min/g, 1.0 pts, 1.5 reb, 1.0 blk, left after freshman season

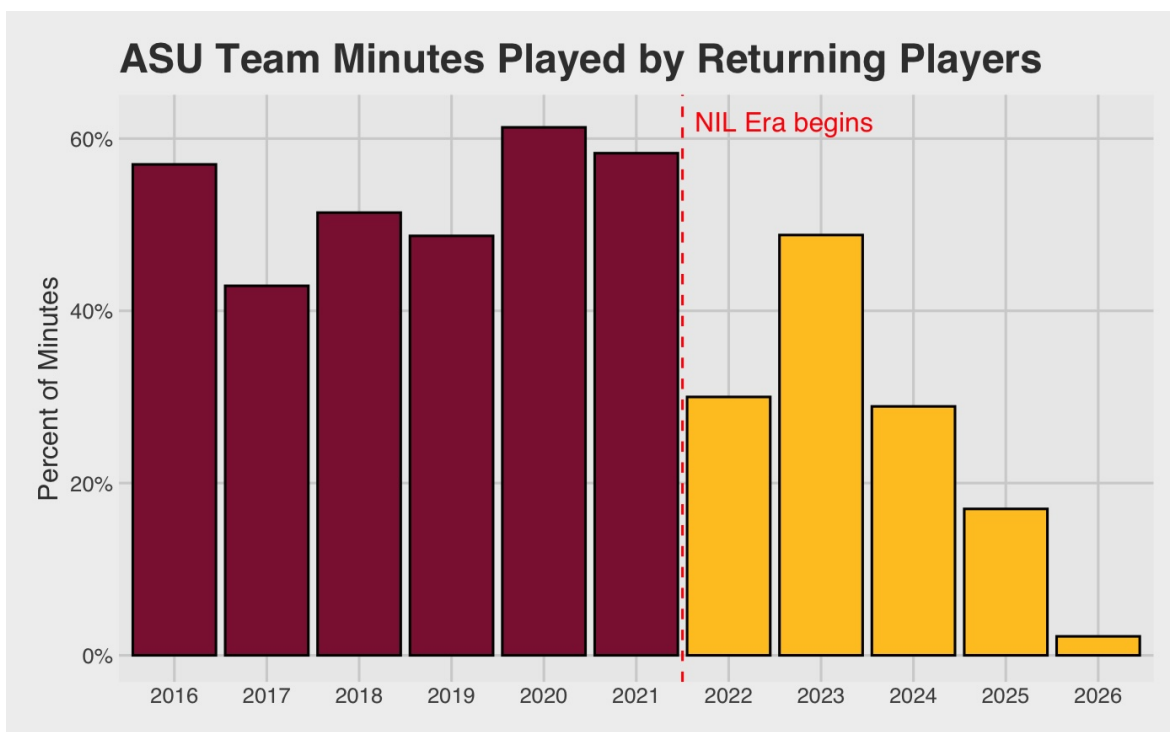


Figure 5: Was It Something I Said?

- Taeshon Cherry (5-star in 2018)
 - 17.8 min, 5.1 pts, 2.9 reb, 37.3 FG%, 30.4 3P%
- Elias Valtonen (4-star in 2018)
 - 8.7 min/g, 1.4 pts/g, 1.1 reb/g, 50 3P% in two season
- Marcus Bagley (4-star in 2020)
 - Career marred by injuries and a [public awkward spat](#) with Hurley
- Enoch Boakye (5-star in 2021)
 - 50 games, 8.9 min/g, 1.5 pts, 2.4 reb, 0.7 blk in 2 seasons; transferred to Fresno State and then Villanova
 - Lead Mountain West, Big East in REB% in 23-24, 24-25
 - 2.9 BPM in 2024-25, .139 WS/48
- Austin Nuñez (4-star in 2022)
 - 15.7 min, 4.2 pts, 40.9 FG%, 37.3 3P%
- Amier Ali (4-star in 2024)
 - 19.2 min, 5.5 pts (37.2 FG%, 32.6 3P%), 3.1 reb

At first glance, this exercise might seem unfair. “Lots of big programs have top recruits that flame out. This is just a copout.”

Unfortunately, it’s not a copout to fit an agenda. Coach Hurley consistently has extremely talented recruits on his roster, but a large majority of them don’t develop. There are more besides the ones above:

- Jaelen House left and became a stud at New Mexico after playing sparingly at ASU.
- Jayden Quaintance looked immature in his freshman year and he left after one season (to be fair, he got the Brinks truck from Kentucky).
- Joson Sanon left for St. John's after an iffy freshman year.

Outside of Lu Dort, Massamba Diop, Josh Christopher, Kimani Lawrence, and Romello White, Hurley has either whiffed or failed to develop marquee freshmen. Diop might be Hurley's greatest development success story, but of course, he left for greener pastures in Spokane.

There was something fundamentally wrong with the Sun Devils' recruiting strategy under Hurley. That is far too many missteps made with elite recruiting classes; many didn't pan out and others developed at other programs. Coach Hurley relied mainly on players who developed with other schools. That unfortunate rap sheet contributed to the lack of faith the players had in him and why they chose to leave.

Performance Review

The previous section provided some not-so-subtle foreshadowing to this section: Coach Hurley's Devils have sputtered in recent seasons:

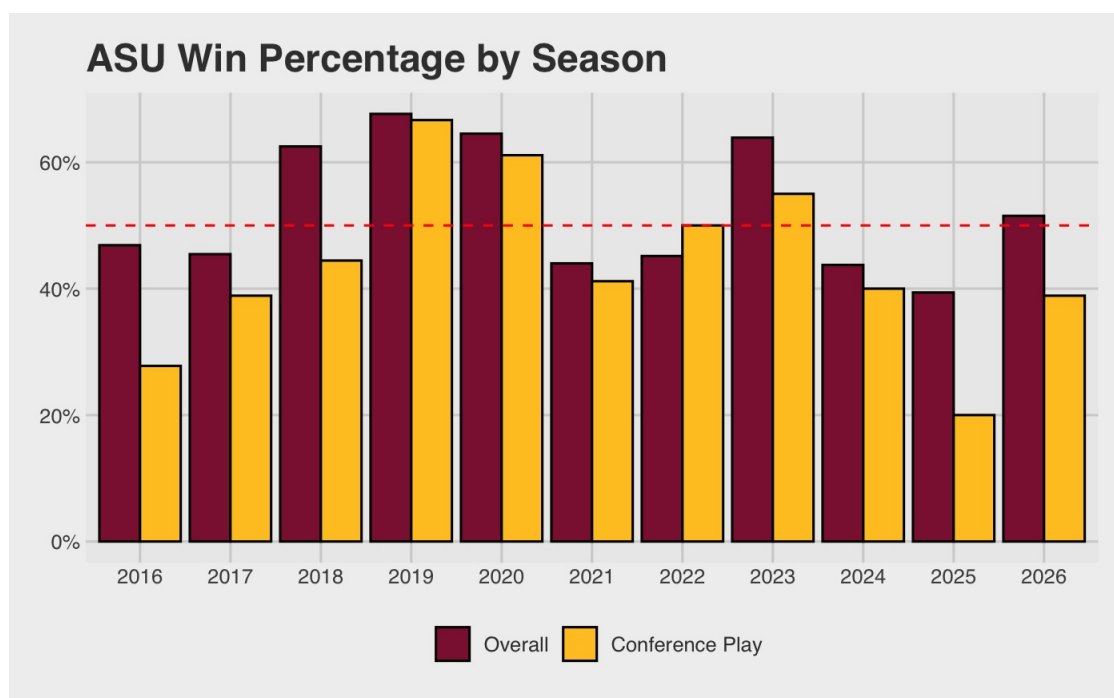


Figure 6: ASU's win percentage by season

After three straight seasons with a win percentage greater than 60%, four of the next six seasons concluded with a record below .500. Given the level of recruits and transfer acquisitions, that is simply not good enough. ASU's goal was to become an "elite basketball program," and while Hurley has recruited very well, it has not translated to an elite on-court product [1].

There is a counterargument to that point and it utilizes the often-referenced Kenpom rankings. I don't have Kenpom premium, so I'm going to use a near-equal substitute: Basketball-Reference's Simple Rating System (SRS). If you were to glance at SRS, ASU ranks very highly, arguably in the elite tier of programs:

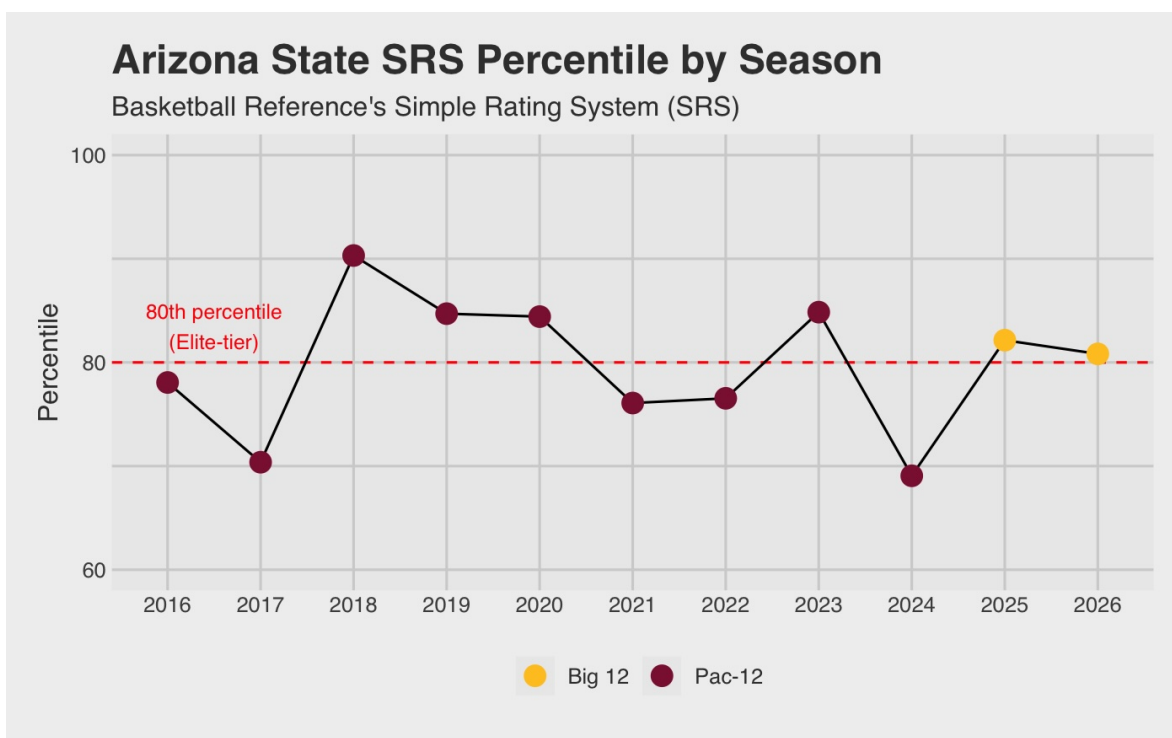


Figure 7: Elite!

NOTE: The y-axis begins at 60; I made this decision because Hurley's squads rarely had an SRS percentile below 70 because of their status as a Power Five team.

"He did produce elite teams, you hack! Six of Hurley's eleven seasons produced a team that was within the top twenty percent of teams by SRS." I don't buy it. First, as previously mentioned, ASU plays in a Power Five Conference. Following the jump to the Big 12, they now play in the arguably deepest and strongest conference in the country (top three in conference SRS in 2025 and 2026). SRS is directly impacted by a team's strength of schedule, so given that ASU was playing very strong competition in conference play, they are able to manufacture a high SRS simply by existing. Furthermore, as seen in Figure 6, ASU had a winning record in conference play in only three of Coach Hurley's eleven seasons. They might be an elite team relative to mid-major programs, but they are certainly an average power five program, save for the three seasons in which they qualified for the Big Dance. More on that later.

Another crude test is to compare the SRS of Hurley's squads to those of his predecessor, Herb Sendek.

Sendek's coaching tenure reads like a terrifying rollercoaster¹, but he did reach greater heights than Hurley in terms of SRS. "He had James Harden!" He sure did...for two whole seasons. That only made up two of his nine seasons as head coach and he built two very strong teams without The Beard in 2010 and 2014. Coach Hurley certainly

¹This graph also has a y-axis beginning at a non-zero value, but once again, ASU will never have a percentile between 0-50 (except 2012 under Sendek)

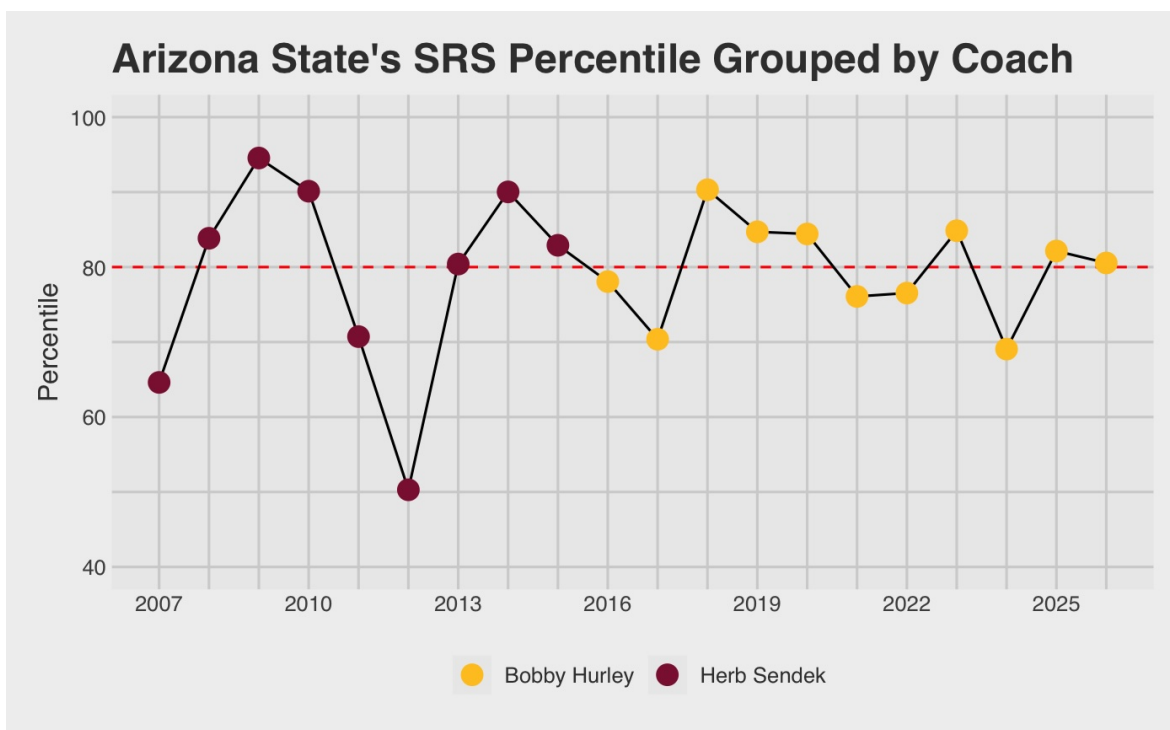


Figure 8: A lateral move?

had more consistency in his time at ASU, but as we previously discussed, he had no shortage of high-end talent walking through the doors, and he did not build an elite program.

For additional assurance, I ran a Brunner-Munzel test on their SRS percentile finishes. This test just asks the question “If you picked a random season from Hurley’s and Sendek’s time at ASU, does Hurley have a higher SRS percentile?” It’s non-parametric and works for small sample sizes:

$$\begin{aligned}
 H_o &: P(\theta_{HS} < \theta_{BH}) = P(\theta_{HS} > \theta_{BH}) \\
 H_a &: P(\theta_{HS} < \theta_{BH}) > P(\theta_{HS} > \theta_{BH}) \\
 \text{Observed p-value: } p &= 0.4326
 \end{aligned}$$

There was no significant difference in consistent “eliteness” after the transition from Sendek to Hurley, it’s been corroborated by the eye test and a statistical test.

SRS rankings are nice, but they lack context. Another powerful summary statistic is Net Rating, which is a team’s offensive rating subtracted by their defensive rating. The offensive and defensive rating of a team are calculated as points scored and allowed per 100 possessions, respectively. This adjusts for teams that play at an incredibly fast or slow pace, so they are on the same playing field. Speaking of slow pace, welcome Coach Bennett!

Kenpom’s adjusted offensive and defensive ratings are based on a team’s performance combined with their strength of schedule. It gives a boost to teams like ASU that play in more difficult conferences. As I previously stated, I don’t have access to Kenpom premium, but using Basketball Reference’s Off. and Def. ratings, SRS, and strength of schedule (SOS), I was able to feature engineer a “Kenpom-lite” version of adjusted offensive and defensive rating, and thus adjusted net rating. Here’s a graph of ASU’s

approximate Kenpom-adjusted net rating percentile in general and when restricted to power five programs:

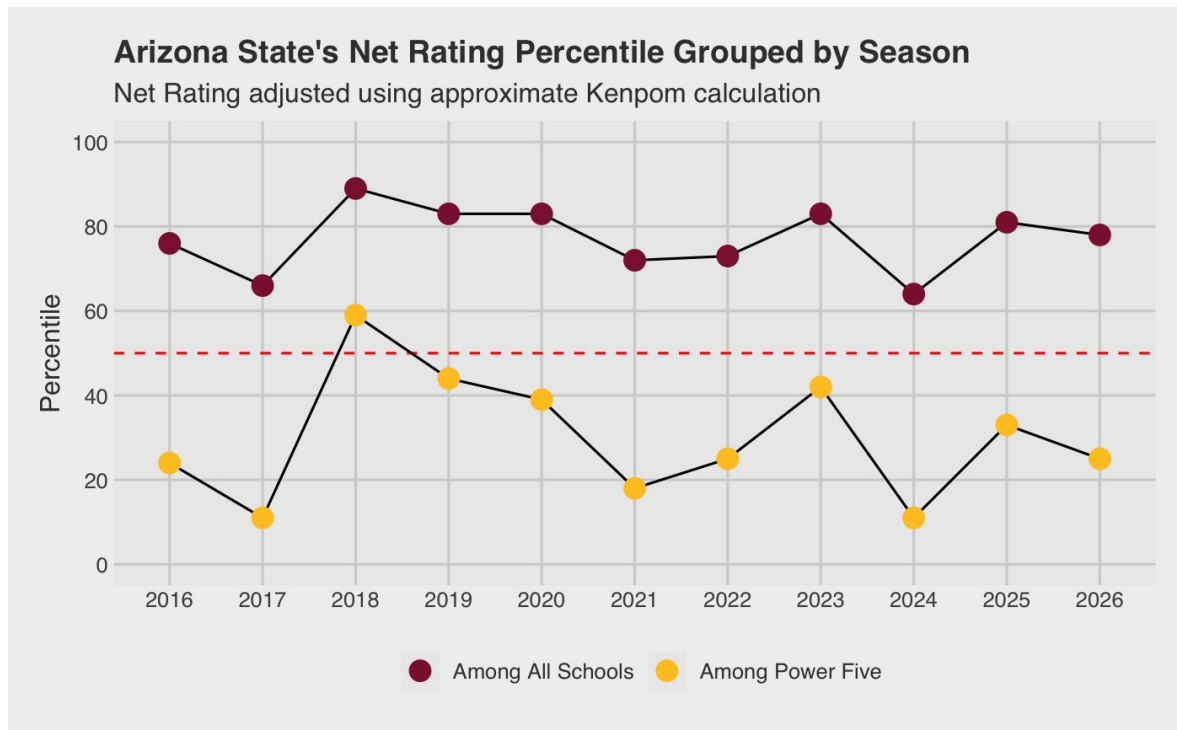


Figure 9: Is the elite team in the room with us?

This is the crux of my argument. I can't consider ASU an elite team when they are usually in the bottom crop of Power Five teams. How could you consider this to be an elite program when they've posted a .500 record in conference play four times in the last eleven years? This past season, ASU had a miraculous win over Kansas, with Darryn Peterson suiting up and playing in the second half. The final score does not do justice to how well the Sun Devils played. They strangled the Jayhawks from the moment the game tipped off. They pulled off an equally stunning win against a healthy Texas Tech team. The reaction following those results was littered with the word "upset" because ASU just isn't on that level. Coach Hurley's men always play hard and make sure no opponent can take the night off, but that can only go so far. We saw the graph of their debut Big 12 campaign (Figure 4); they were skewered on a nightly basis.

Rather than using offensive and defensive rating percentiles, I'm going to use offensive and defensive four factors. These provide even more context, plus they can isolate specific areas in which ASU is consistently outclassed. Spoiler alert (Figure 10).

As a regular viewer of ASU basketball, I was often frustrated by several things year after year. I'm going to highlight my armchair grievances and how Figure 10 supports them:

- "We can't shoot!"
 - ASU has been in the bottom third of Power Five teams in $eFG\%$ for six of the last seven years.
- "Why can't we play defense without fouling?"

Percentiles	Offensive Four Factors				Defensive Four Factors			
Season	eFG%	TOV%	ORB%	FT/FGA	eFG%	TOV%	ORB%	FT/FGA
2015-16	21	60	51	43	4	61	79	31
2016-17	47	97	4	32	1	44	11	67
2017-18	75	95	19	96	29	84	28	35
2018-19	40	40	67	97	59	64	72	11
2019-20	33	52	25	37	29	91	48	33
2020-21	32	95	3	72	14	86	24	4
2021-22	8	53	8	1	84	67	24	21
2022-23	17	67	43	37	87	74	14	18
2023-24	8	71	1	25	15	89	34	63
2024-25	41	16	5	70	38	28	28	42
2025-26	23	10	29	91	18	81	3	34

Figure 10: Eight Factors (AMONG POWER FIVE TEAMS)

- In nine of ASU’s eleven seasons with Coach Hurley, they were in the bottom 40 percent in defensive *FT/FGA*, meaning they conceded free throws at a very unfavorable rate.
- “Our teams never have any size.”
 - ASU has been bad at both offensive rebounding and clearing the glass for about seven years.

Having both offensive and defensive four factors allows us to view these figures with the proper context. Offensive rebounding could potentially be attributed to philosophical tendencies; certain teams choose not to crash the offensive glass in favor of getting back and preventing transition opportunities. However, ASU being poor on both sides of the rebounding spectrum takes air out of that argument.

Unfortunately, as I mentioned above, I wasn’t surprised that ASU consistently was poor in both shooting and limiting fouls. On a more positive note, I mentioned that ASU played with intensity matching their coach’s, and that’s reflected in their ability to generate turnovers. That has Bobby Hurley written all over it. On the offensive side, they are usually careful with the ball, but the transition to the Big 12 has not been kind. That’s what playing teams like Houston, Cincinnati, and Iowa State multiple times a year will do to a team.

Speaking of identity, here are some more percentiles among Power Five teams (Figure 11).

ASU had a pace in the top 30 percent in eight of Coach Hurley’s eleven seasons. I ask: Why? What traits did ASU possess that justify this philosophy? Sure, they forced a lot of turnovers, they usually took care of the ball and had a few seasons of drawing fouls at an elite rate². However, they couldn’t shoot nor clear the glass, and their *AST%* was poor more often than not. I understand that coaches have a vision for their team, but these teams were not executing the ideal vision of a fast, high-powered offense. Playing at a fast pace but not being able to shoot, make plays, or rebound at a high level is an example of an identity that does not fit the team.

²Thank you Moe Odum

Season	Pace	FTr	3PAr	TS%	REB%	AST%
2015-16	65	51	85	15	40	33
2016-17	84	20	97	49	1	23
2017-18	95	95	85	83	15	31
2018-19	93	100	23	52	73	39
2019-20	97	43	49	32	16	4
2020-21	89	62	43	39	3	24
2021-22	55	1	55	1	11	58
2022-23	70	55	72	17	20	75
2023-24	81	51	56	5	3	28
2024-25	82	78	75	47	9	30
2025-26	80	90	38	41	10	42

Figure 11: ASU's identity percentiles among Power Five teams

This Is Our Super Bowl

To recap, I've shown that Coach Hurley could recruit, but struggled to develop and retain talent. His teams were mediocre in a Power Five context, and the four factors highlight a lack of cohesion between vision and results.

This is a negative sentiment towards a team that is competitive on a yearly basis and has both made and won in March Madness. The 2023 Sun Devils were both extremely fun and very good. However, as I have learned from following Loyola Marymount, sometimes you have to limit the scope of your expectations as a fan. If LMU secures an unlikely win against conference rivals Saint Mary's or Gonzaga, I could not care less how poorly the rest of the season goes. I apply a similar line of reasoning to the Arizona State-Arizona rivalry: The Duel of the Desert³. Coach Hurley could earn a lot of goodwill if he could beat the Sun Devils' hated rival (Figure 12).

Cue the Joel Embiid quote about Boston. Two wins⁴ this decade. Outside of the 2018-19 season, ASU is 2-19 against the Wildcats under Hurley. Full disclosure: This is not an entirely fair exercise. Arizona was on a higher level prior to Hurley's appointment, and they have only gotten better in recent years under Tommy Lloyd. However, given everything I have highlighted, it would be nice if Arizona State could pull off the "we suck, but not today" feat that is seen in other rivalries like Patriots-Dolphins and Army-Navy.

Concluding Remarks

The plot displaying ASU's performance against Arizona might read like kicking the man while he's down, but I argue that this visual reinforces an emerging theme about Coach Hurley's time at ASU: He had an established floor, but the ceiling of his teams was very low. Recall the problems I've laid out: Issues developing high-end recruits, recurring problems scoring, the negative record in conference play, the annual personnel volatility, and the lack of noticeable improvement compared to Herb Sendek. Coach Hurley built teams that were tough, scrappy, and gritty. At their best, his squads could

³The basketball version

⁴The Desmond Cambridge half court heave in 2023 is easily the best ASU basketball moment in recent memory.

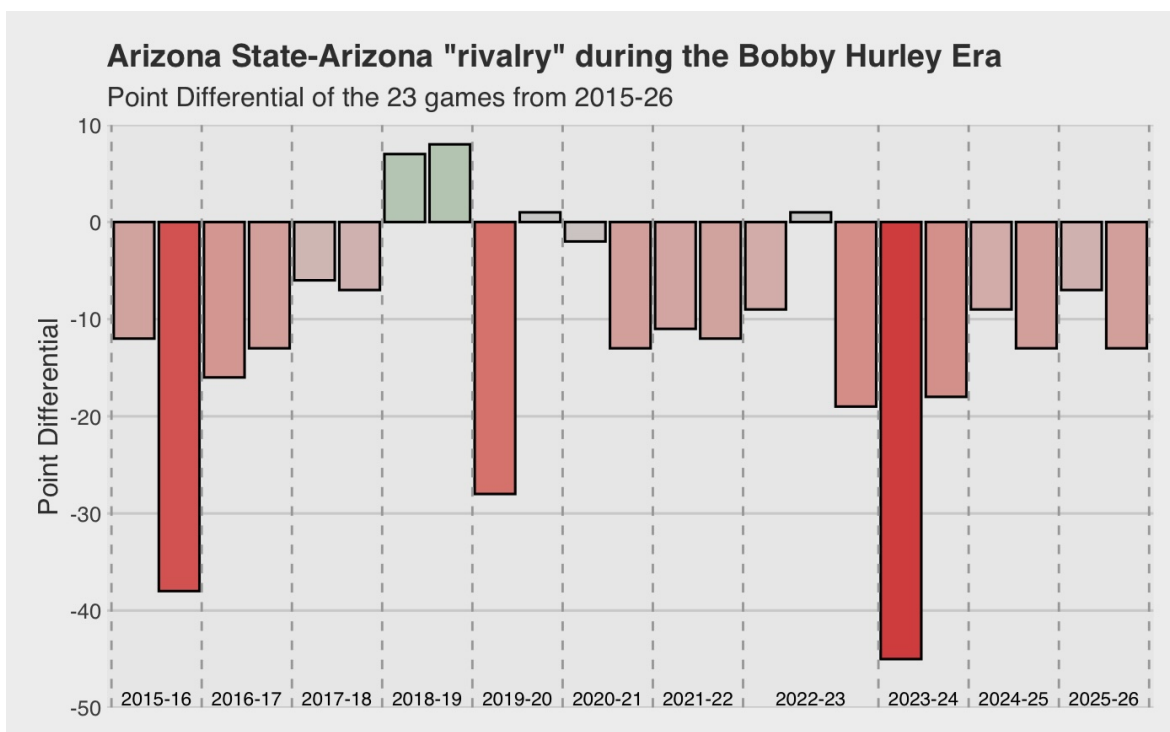


Figure 12: 4-19 against U of A since 2015

grind their way to an 11-seed and a First Four berth. At their worst, they played games in an ugly and chaotic fashion. If they are serious about being a respectable Big 12 program and not getting beat down for the huge pay day, then they need to address the organizational motifs that emerged during Hurley's time at ASU.

Epilogue

Coach Randy Bennett coached Saint Mary's for a very long time and always assembled groups that executed at a high level. Him and his uncanny eye for foreign talent always found a way to do more with less and turn a small school in Moraga into a multiple-time WCC regular season and tournament champion—in a conference with Gonzaga. As an LMU alum, watching Saint Mary's was a painful endeavor. They played slow, ugly, but effective basketball. His gameplan was simple: Slow the game down, control the number of possessions, and limit mistakes. His teams squeezed the life out of games and did so with very little flash: passing, rebounding, and waiting until the best shot is open.

I included the heatmaps for Saint Mary's during the same time frame (Figures 13 and 14). Once again, this is a very crude exercise; these are Saint Mary's percentiles among Power Five teams. Saint Mary's is not a Power Five, but this is to establish that their metrics on paper are very respectable. There's no point in comparing them to mid-majors because they are in a league of their own⁵. A couple of notes: Saint Mary's had an off year in 2021, but the heatmaps highlight a team that is very fundamentally sound. They lack athleticism and star power, but they get the absolute most out of their rosters.

⁵Unless you consider Gonzaga a mid-major

In theory, Coach Bennett is bringing his tactical acumen to a program in which he should have an easier time landing recruits. This feels like it should be an upgrade, and Coach Bennett must feel that way too if he felt compelled enough to leave Saint Mary's after twenty-five years of service.

Percentiles	Offensive Four Factors				Defensive Four Factors			
Season	eFG%	TOV%	ORB%	FT/FGA	eFG%	TOV%	ORB%	FT/FGA
2015-16	99	36	84	5	88	14	88	100
2016-17	99	71	61	11	99	5	100	93
2017-18	99	34	86	36	57	11	100	92
2018-19	88	62	88	25	55	18	99	59
2019-20	99	16	97	42	8	39	99	71
2020-21	13	22	57	25	81	57	100	70
2021-22	84	31	53	9	69	75	99	86
2022-23	74	81	77	48	82	79	100	29
2023-24	74	99	72	10	98	63	100	38
2024-25	23	99	90	21	94	43	100	98
2025-26	54	91	26	84	90	44	99	93

Figure 13: SMC's Four Factors percentiles

Season	Pace	FTr	3PAr	TS%	REB%	AST%
2015-16	3	7	86	99	82	91
2016-17	3	7	93	95	99	96
2017-18	4	20	37	99	95	63
2018-19	3	11	21	84	93	1
2019-20	7	32	42	100	53	5
2020-21	10	19	56	10	73	8
2021-22	17	5	52	83	83	35
2022-23	4	64	53	68	95	25
2023-24	2	16	41	57	100	80
2024-25	4	30	9	20	100	70
2025-26	15	61	31	68	96	71

Figure 14: SMC's identity percentiles

References

- [1] ESPN.com news services, “Bobby Hurley hired at Arizona State,” *ESPN.com*, 9 Apr. 2015, [URL](#).
- [2] Iowa State, “Cyclones Crush Sun Devils in Historic Big 12 Tournament Win,” *cyclones.com*, 11 Mar. 2026, [URL](#).
- [3] Polacek, Scott, “ASU’s Marcus Bagley Says He Was Suspended for Tweet About Bobby Hurley Incident,” *Bleacher Report*, 29 Nov. 2022, [URL](#).
- [4] Data was taken from Sports-Reference and Kenpom.
- [5] Data aggregation and visualization was done using a combination of Python, R, and Excel.